Home ▸ All Journals ▸ Humanities ▸ Philosophical Psychology ▸ List of Issues

Full Article Figures & data References Citations Share

Metrics Reprints & Permissions Read this article

Philosophical Psychology ›

Volume 37, 2024 - Issue 5

331 Views | 1 CrossRef citations to date | Altmetric

Research Article

What underlies death/suicide implicit association test measures and how it contributes to suicidal action

René Baston

Pages 993-1016 | Received 01 Mar 2021, Accepted 30 Mar 2022, Published online: 07 Apr 2022

Cite this article https://doi.org/10.1080/09515089.2022.2061342 Check for updates

Sample our Humanities Journals

>> Sign in here to start your access to the latest two volumes for 14 days

ABSTRACT

Recently, psychologists have developed indirect measurement procedures to predict suicidal behavior. A prominent example is the Death/Suicide Implicit Association Test (DS-IAT). In this paper, I argue that there is something special about the DS-IAT which distinguishes it from different IAT measures. I argue that the DS-IAT does not measure weak or strong associations between the implicit self-concept and the abstract concept of death. In contrast, assuming a goal-system approach, I suggest that sorting death-related to self-related words takes effort because death-related words trigger avoidance-impulses, which suicide ideation weakens. The DS-IAT taps into weakened automatic responses from the self-preservation system. Additionally,

Suicidology implicit bias agency self-control selfish goal theory

Disclosure statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author(s).

Notes

1. I think that implicit cognition only plays a crucial role for some types of suicidal agents.

2. An individual who considers suicide counts as a suicide ideator.

3. One of the strongest risk factors are past suicidal attempts, but the SI-IAT outruns this risk factor. This makes it implausible that the SI-IAT does simply measure the memory-traces of past suicidal attempts.

4. I am open to the idea that goal-systems use different underlying mechanisms than associations.

5. Arguably, when agents are undergoing a classic IAT measure, similar mechanisms are at play. For instance, if participants are hungry, it is harder for them to sort food-related words to the value-label *bad* (Stafford & Scheffler, 2008). The goal to eat, here a motivation that gained power, influences the participants' IAT performance, which seems unexplainable with memory's associations between food and value-based concepts.

Additional information

Notes on contributors

René Baston

René Baston finished his PhD studies on the nature of implicit prejudices in 2019. He currently works as a postdoctoral researcher at the Heinrich-Heine University in Düsseldorf, Germany.

Related Research Data

Know Thyself
Source: Perspectives on Psychological Science
The Automatic Evaluation of Novel Stimuli
Source: Psychological Science
Are “implicit” attitudes unconscious?
Source: Consciousness and Cognition
Top-down and bottom-up mechanisms in biasing competition in the human brain
Source: Vision Research
Characteristics of Impulsive Suicide Attempts and Attempters
Source: Suicide and Life-Threatening Behavior
From decision to action: Suicidal history and time between decision to die and actual suicide attempt
Source: Clinical Psychology & Psychotherapy

Related research

People also read Recommended articles Cited by 1

Home ▶ All Journals ▶ Humanities ▶ Philosophical Psychology ▶ List of Issues

Full Article Figures & data References Citations Share

Metrics Reprints & Permissions Read this article

Philosophical Psychology
Published online: 29 May 2024

Information for

Authors
R&D professionals
Editors
Librarians
Societies

Open access

Overview
Open journals
Open Select
Dove Medical Press
F1000Research

Opportunities

Reprints and e-prints
Advertising solutions
Accelerated publication
Corporate access solutions

Help and information

Help and contact
Newsroom
All journals
Books

Keep up to date

Register to receive personalised research and resources by email

Sign me up

Copyright © 2026 **Informa UK Limited** Privacy policy Cookies Terms & conditions Accessibility

Registered in England & Wales No. 01072954
5 Howick Place | London | SW1P 1WG